

6, Regarding the Issues Encountered During Writing, and a Hope for Understanding

Up until I graduated from my undergraduate studies and returned to Xi'an (西安), all the discoveries and insights worth writing about are contained herein; this period of slightly over half a year has indeed been extraordinary for me. Yet even so, the more new things I discover, the clearer it becomes that there are still many problems beyond my personal capacity to resolve, and the narratives in many places inevitably contain inadequacies. What worries me is not that there are still too many things I do not understand, because even the most erudite scholar cannot exhaust all the knowledge in the world. *Life is finite, while knowledge is infinite; this is an eternal sorrow, so why grieve over it?*

However, China's social environment is peculiar; those aspects of official doctrines that align with reason are **as rare as phoenix feathers and unicorn horns** (凤毛麟角). Coupled with artificially constructed information barriers, it is indeed tremendously difficult to align with the international community on many concepts. When I arrived at domains untouched by predecessors, I could only tentatively name some new phenomena myself, making unreasonable aspects unavoidable. For some of the narratives inherited from our country's traditional expressions that have already been mentioned, I once again extend my apologies here to any potential readers.

For instance, the term "**slavery society** (奴隶制社会)" in Chinese originates from the Soviet five-stage theory [五段论]. Although even people of insight in China have long known that the **slavery society** is fundamentally not the dualistically opposed social structure of slave owners and slaves as claimed by the Bolshevik (布尔什维克), there is no more precise term available domestically as a substitute, so I have no choice but to continue using it. Whether the ruling **class** (阶级) of this period can be generalized as the "slave-owning class" is also highly questionable. In my previous narratives, I substituted the term "ruling class of the slavery society" with "the early nobility evolved from clan chieftains, religious priests, and military commanders (using 'early' to contrast with the landed nobility generated during the period of **feudalization** (封建化))", but this is merely my personal perspective.

An even greater issue lies in designations such as "**capitalist society** (资本主义社会)" and "**capitalist state** (资本主义国家)". The Chinese officialdom uniformly adopts this descriptive method for Western Europe and the United States. Although its flaws are blatantly obvious, before gaining a profound understanding of the societies of these nations, I have no way to formulate alternative naming conventions and can only adopt the general domestic terminology. The complexity of modern social structure and the meticulousness of the division of labor are unprecedented. **Class** division is exponentially more difficult now—not only compared to before the Industrial Revolution, but even compared to the era of Marx (马克思). Today, the term "**capitalist society**" indeed carries the suspicion of excessively exaggerating the **class** contradiction between the bourgeoisie [资产阶级] and the proletariat [无产阶级] as being **as incompatible as fire and water** (水火不容) (though anyone who truly believes there is zero contradiction is simply a fool). Yet, if one broadly refers to Western nations as "democratic states" [民主国家], this evidently fails to grasp the fundamental commonality of these countries; Western democratic systems are clearly built upon the foundation of certain social realities and could not possibly have grown out of thin air. As long as one observes those countries that lack social conditions equivalent to the West but attempt to

forcibly transplant Western democratic systems, the failure of such political practices is a common occurrence.

Personally, regarding this issue, I am actually more inclined to reinterpret the so-called "XX-system societies." That is, to emphasize the status of the **primary factor of production** (首位生产要素) acting as the modifier, supplemented by the **mainstream mode of exploitation** (主流剥削方式), while no longer emphasizing the high degree of antagonism between the ruling **class** and the ruled **class** as the principal characteristic. For example, a **slavery society** is a society where labor occupies the primary position among various factors of production, and where the direct exploitation of labor through forced labor serves as the **mainstream mode of exploitation**. A **feudal society** (封建社会) is a society where land occupies the primary position among various factors of production (means of production), and where the exploitation of agricultural surplus through the collection of rent and taxes—including corvée rent—serves as the **mainstream mode of exploitation**. A **capitalist society** is a society where capital occupies the primary position among various factors of production (means of production), and where the exploitation of workers' surplus value [剩余价值] (tentatively recorded this way in accordance with Marx's phrasing) serves as the **mainstream mode of exploitation**.

Redefining them in this manner would perhaps be more reasonable, and it is also more meaningful from the perspective of a Chinese person. After all, approaches like Marx's—which only consider **class** contradictions within typical **class** societies—are evidently completely insufficient to explain the history of the Chinese empire [中华帝国]. The principal contradiction here can be entirely described as that between the bureaucratic **stratum** (阶层) and all other **classes**. This is also why, since I began writing these texts in 2023, I have strongly emphasized that while the righteousness and rationality of the oppressed people's resistance must be affirmed, one must adopt a prudent attitude when discussing the contradictions between the ruling **class** and the ruled **class**. This is because the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) exploiting this point is no longer a mere possibility; it has been a century-long reality occurring since the establishment of Soviet Russia (苏俄). **One cannot constantly stumble in the exact same place repeatedly** (在同一个地方不停跌倒).

Of course, readers of these records should not think that I have made no contributions whatsoever to the use of these concepts. For things outside of China that I do not understand, there is indeed nothing I can do, but regarding concepts related to Chinese history, I have still done a great deal of work in **setting things right** (拨乱反正). For example, the Chinese official narrative calls the period from the Qin (秦) to Qing (清) dynasties our country's **feudal period** (封建时期). I have obviously completely discarded this idiotic theory used to deceive the common people.

In my narrative, I refer to the period from the Qin, both Han, up to the Western Jin dynasties (秦代两汉一直到西晋) as the **classical empire** (古典帝国) or China during the **classical period** (古典时期). Meanwhile, what I call "Feudal China" [封建中国] merely refers to Chinese society during the four hundred years spanning the 3rd, 4th, 5th, and 6th centuries CE, which is what the international Sinology community refers to as "Early Medieval China" [早期中世纪中国]. From the 7th century until the end of the Qing Dynasty, I have consistently adopted the designation "**restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家)" (or society), while pointing out that the **restoration-bureaucratic state** began to mature during the Song Dynasty (宋代).

I have also made a distinction in the designations for the ruling class [统治阶级] oppressed under the bureaucratic system [官僚制度] in China, and the ruling class under the **feudal political system** (封建

政治制度) represented by Western Europe and Japan. In China, I simply call them the landlord class [地主阶级]. Only for regimes during the Northern and Southern Dynasties (南北朝) where **feudalization** (封建化) was relatively pronounced, or for border regimes like Dali (大理) that had already been feudalized, do I adopt the same designation used for the ruling classes of Europe and Japan, namely "**feudal lords** (封建领主)".

Another area where readers might have obvious doubts is that when I compare Europe and Japan, there is a distinct difference in the terminologies used on both sides. For example, according to the Japanese's own periodization, immediately after the end of the **Chūsei** (中世), it is already the **early modern period** (近世). However, according to the general translations of Europe's periodization in Chinese academia, when the **Middle Ages** (中世纪) ended in 1453, it was clearly still quite a distance away from what Europeans consider the "modern era" [近代]. The time in between was named the "early modern" [早近代], or, named after the major historical events that occurred at the time, the "Reformation and Enlightenment period" [宗教改革和启蒙运动时期].

My approach to handling this is to uniformly map the Western concept of "early modern" into Chinese using terms equivalent to the "**近世/近代**", generally no longer adopting the literal translation of "**早期近代**". For Europe after 1800, I will directly use the term "modern" [现代] to describe it, while the period approaching the present is referred to as "contemporary" [当代]. The relevant reasons are explained in Chapter 12, Section 30.

What I want to say is that the reason such a massive discrepancy arises in the Chinese translations of the periodizations of Europe and Japan is that Europe is a continent vastly larger than Japan, containing many different regimes. The fact is, the fundamental reason 1453 is marked as the chronological node for the end of the **Middle Ages** is that landmark historical events such as the end of the Hundred Years' War (百年战争) and the fall of the Eastern Roman Empire (东罗马帝国) occurred at both ends of the continent. However, this does not mean that the social structure underwent a massive transformation across such a vast region within a short period of time. This is completely different from the changes in Japan—**like a violent storm** (疾风骤雨般)—over the 30 years from Oda Nobunaga (织田信长) marching into Kyoto (*jōraku* (上洛)) to the death of Toyotomi Hideyoshi (丰臣秀吉) from illness.

Furthermore, people must get used to the fact that the existence of a transition between two "typical" social stages is an inevitable occurrence. For example, when people mention Europe's **absolutist states** (绝对主义国家), the first thing that comes to mind is undoubtedly France under the rule of the Bourbon Dynasty (波旁王朝). But did the **absolutist state** truly only begin to emerge in the 17th and 18th centuries? If one observes *The Prince* (《君主论》) written by Machiavelli (马基雅维利), it is not hard to discover that this work—which called for a powerful monarch to save Italy (though the author himself ultimately hoped for a republic [共和])—was published in 1532. At this time, no country in all of Europe could be definitively called an **absolutist state**.

However, human thought cannot possibly exist detached from social reality. The fact that Machiavelli could write *The Prince* somewhat demonstrates that many factors supporting the formation of an **absolutist state** had already emerged within his society (such as the emphasis on attitudes toward citizens, the diversification of methods to seize ruling power, and the monarch's ways of utilizing personnel). The **absolutist state** was already in the process of forming. This is

precisely why I believe there is no need to carve out a separate stage between the end of a typical **feudal society** (封建社会) like the **Middle Ages** and the formation of a typical **absolutist state**. It is entirely sufficient to merely view it as the earlier portion of the "**early modern society**" (近世社会) during the transitional period. Both the Reformation [宗教改革运动] and the Enlightenment [启蒙运动] themselves are simply prominent external manifestations of this transition.

As for why I equate what Europeans consider the **absolutist state** (绝对主义国家) with what the Japanese consider the **early modern state** (近世国家), the reason lies in the fact that many characteristics of the Edo shogunate (江户幕府) were indeed identical to those of Europe's **absolutist states**. However, I must also say that the developmental level of the Edo shogunate simply could not be mentioned in the same breath as that of Western European countries like Britain and France. This was determined by Japan's national scale, diplomatic scope, and geographical location, and it was also the result of Japan's **feudalization** (封建化) beginning relatively late.

For instance, people can easily point out the most conspicuous difference between the Edo shogunate and Europe's **absolutist states**: the latter had an extremely high proportion of military expenditure in their fiscal spending and were exceptionally bellicose. Conversely, the Edo period was an exceedingly rare era of prolonged peace in Japanese history; Japan's massive expansion actually occurred from the Meiji (明治) to the early Showa (昭和) periods, right after the shogunate ended.

But then again, just as I already mentioned when writing the section on Japan, Japanese society started far too late compared to Europe. Each of its "standard" historical periods often had to wait until its final stretch of time to exhibit typicality. For example, the so-called classical Japan only truly possessed distinct characteristics of a **classical state** (古典国家) during its final 100 years—the Insei (院政 / Cloistered Rule) period of the Heian era (平安时代). The so-called **Chūsei** (中世) Japan only ultimately realized a **feudal society** (封建社会) fundamentally identical to Europe's during its final 100 years—the Sengoku period (战国时期). Therefore, it is perfectly normal for Japan's **early modern society** (近世社会) to also exhibit this kind of lag.

There is absolutely no need to **discard the entire body just for the sake of a tail** (为了一根尾巴而放弃全身). Just as the Japanese would not refuse to call the pre-Insei Heian period "classical Japan," nor would they refuse to call the Kamakura (镰仓) and early Muromachi (室町) periods prior to the Sengoku period "**Chūsei** society." When people mention that the Azuchi-Momoyama regime (安土桃山政权) placed immense importance on and heavily relied upon cities and circulation, and when people pay attention to the rich material and spiritual lives of the *chōnin* (町人 / townsmen) in Edo, this already affirms that Edo-period Japan possessed the characteristics of an **early modern state**, and possessed the characteristics of an **absolutist state** (such as the growing strength of the civic class [市民阶级]).

When the Japanese speak of the "**early modern period**" (近世), they emphasize temporal characteristics; when Europeans speak of "absolutism" (绝对主义), they emphasize manifestations in social features. I have simply combined the two and refer to it as the "early modern absolutist state (society/stage)" (近世绝对主义国家 (社会/阶段)). This should not cause any reading difficulties.

I personally also have some issues regarding naming conventions, and I can only ask the readers who come across them to bear with me. For instance, when describing the period of the Great

Migration [民族大迁徙], after the **barbarians** (蛮族) entered the Chinese heartland, they did not choose to undergo **feudalization** (封建化) in accordance with the general laws of social development. Instead, they reached a compromise with the Han Chinese landlords [汉族地主] and pivoted toward a policy of bureaucratization [官僚化]. I termed this compromise "**The Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise** (地主-官僚妥协)". This nomenclature can obviously easily cause misunderstandings, leading people to mistakenly believe that the two compromising parties were the bureaucrats and the landlords.

Furthermore, for those who are relatively familiar with Chinese history, it is even easier to mistake it for another social phenomenon—namely, the already re-established **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) executing **co-optation through official ranks and stipends** (官位荣禄收买) to win over the **aristocratic great clans** (门阀士族), who were massive landowners. They might think I am describing political maneuvers akin to those behind the centralizing trend of the aristocratic clans moving toward the two capitals of Chang'an (长安) and Luoyang (洛阳) during the Tang Dynasty (唐代).

I admit that I was somewhat hasty in my naming here. What I actually wanted to express is that the small hyphen between "landlord" and "bureaucrat" should be viewed as a rightward-pointing arrow, meaning that the **barbarians** "abandoned becoming landlords to become bureaucrats" (of course, a more precise formulation would be "abandoning becoming **feudal lords** (封建领主) in favor of becoming **bureaucratized landlords** (官僚化地主)"). However, it is obviously highly unlikely for readers to adopt this interpretation initially. If named after the two compromising parties, it ought to be the "Barbarian-Landlord Compromise" [蛮族-地主妥协].

Additionally, a highly regrettable point regarding historical materials is that because China's **feudalization** is a highly remote event that occurred fifteen or sixteen centuries ago for us, in an era lacking printing technology and where paper had just been popularized, historical records could not possibly be as abundant as in later times. The already limited historical materials have been scattered and lost over such a protracted period, leaving even fewer readable ones today. Therefore, aside from rather vague records such as the debate between Liu Yuan (刘渊) and Liu Xuan (刘宣) over what path the Xiongnu (匈奴) should adopt, it is impossible for us to find explicit and blatant accounts like those in the *Jianyan Yilai Xinian Yaolu* (《建炎以来系年要录》) to study how people at that time viewed this compromise. This is simply a reality we have to accept.

As for those highly prevalent translation issues in Chinese, they are even more numerous. For example, in China, the terms "emperor" [皇帝] and "imperial system" [帝制] have been abused to a degree where it is impossible to untangle them. The supreme ruler of Persia (波斯) is called an emperor, the supreme ruler of Mali (马里) is called an emperor, the supreme ruler of the Mughal (莫卧儿) is called an emperor, the supreme ruler of Rome (罗马) is called an emperor, and the supreme ruler of the Holy Roman Empire (神圣罗马帝国) is also called an emperor. Although everyone knows that these foreign monarchs are completely different from Chinese emperors, and even the Chinese emperors of the **restoration-bureaucratic empire** (复辟官僚帝国) are already vastly different from the emperors of the Qin and Han (秦汉) **classical empires** (古典帝国), such appellations have nonetheless been retained. For anyone with a certain understanding of human history, this should not cause any confusion.

I hope readers will not forget that my contemplation and the very act of writing down these texts were completed while bearing academic responsibilities and under conditions severely restricting access to information. The existence of deficiencies is, in many instances, an unavoidable reality.

Finally, I must unleash a complaint about the early 2023 movie *The Wandering Earth II* (《流浪地球2》). Even though this **garbage movie** (破电影) has absolutely nothing to do with what I am writing, I actually bought a ticket to watch this **trashy film conveying anti-humanity values** (传达反人类价值观的烂片). Not roasting it would simply be out of character for me. China's self-proclaimed "patriots" [爱国者] are forever wallowing in these borderline-delusional grand narratives [宏大叙事]. They never spare a single glance at the myriad of visible hardships suffering right before their compatriots' eyes, much less can one expect these guys to speak a word or two in their defense.

To think that after writing so much, I was still swindled out of twenty or thirty bucks by a movie waving the banner of patriotism—this is truly the most brainless act I have committed in the past year.

6，关于写作的时候出现的问题，希望得到理解

直到我本科毕业回到西安为止，所有值得一写的发现和看法都在这里了，这半年多一点的时光对我而言确实是非凡的。可即使如此，我新发现的事物越多就越清楚还有不少问题是我个人的能力难以解决的，很多地方的叙述必然存在不妥之处。让我忧心的并非自己还有太多事不了解，因为即使是最渊博的学者也不可能穷尽天下所有知识，人生有涯，而知无涯，此万古愁也，何必哀之。

然而中国的社会环境特殊，官方学说中合乎情理者凤毛麟角，再加上人为制造的信息壁垒，在很多概念上想要与国际社会接轨确实存在很大困难。当我抵达前人没有涉足过的领域时，对于一些新现象也只能自己先予以命名，有不合理之处在所难免。已经提到过的一些沿袭我国传统表达的叙述，在这里再次对任何潜在的读者表示歉意。像汉语里所说的“奴隶制社会”来自苏联的五段论，虽然哪怕是中国的有识之士也早都知道奴隶制社会根本不是布尔什维克所谓的奴隶主和奴隶二元对立的社会结构，但是国内也没有一个更为精当的词去替代，所以我也只能沿用。这个时期的统治阶级是否可以概括为“奴隶主阶级”也存在很大疑问，我在之前叙述中会把奴隶社会统治阶级这个词替代为“由氏族首领，宗教祭祀和军事统帅演化而成的早期贵族（说早期是与封建化时期产生的土地贵族相对应）”，但这也只是我个人的一种看法。更大的一个问题是“资本主义社会”和“资本主义国家”这样的称呼，中国官方对于西欧和美国统一采取了这样的描述方式，虽然其中的弊病显而易见，但是在没有对这些国家的社会有很深入的了解之前，我也没办法进行别的命名只能沿用国内一般的叫法。现代社会结构之复杂，分工之细致是前所未有的，阶级划分不要说比工业革命之前，即使比马克思的年代也要困难太多，“资本主义社会”这个词在今天确实存在太过夸大资产阶级与无产阶级水火不容的阶级矛盾的嫌疑（但是谁要是真的相信没有矛盾，那就是傻瓜）。可是如果笼统地把西方国家称为“民主国家”，那么这又显然没有抓到这些国家的根本共同点，西方的民主制度显然是建立在一定的社会现实的基础上，而不可能是凭空长出来的。只要观察那些不具备与西方同等社会条件却试图强行移植西方民主体制的国家，政治实践失败是常有之事。

我本人对于这个问题其实更倾向于对于所谓“XX制社会”进行再解释，也就是强调作为限定词的生产要素的首位地位，并辅以主流剥削方式，不再强调统治阶级和被统治阶级高度对立作为主要特征。例如奴隶制社会就是劳动力在各生产要素中处于首位地位，以强迫劳动的方式直接剥削劳动力为最主要的剥削方式的社会；封建社会就是土地在各生产要素（生产资料）中处于首位地位，以收取包括劳役地租的租税的方式剥削农业生产剩余为主要剥削方式的社会；资本主义社会就是资本在各生产要素（生产资料）中处于首位地位，以剥削劳动者剩余价值（依照马克思的说法暂时先这么记录）为主要剥削方式的社会。如果这样重新定义的话或许会更合理一些，而且站在中国人的角度也是更有意义的，毕竟像马克思那种只考虑典型的阶级社会中的阶级矛盾显然完全不足以解释中华帝国的历史，我们这里的主要矛盾

完全可以讲是官僚阶层和其他所有阶级的。这也是为什么我从 23 年开始写这些的时候就非常强调虽然必须肯定被压迫人民反抗的正义性和合理性，但是在谈到统治阶级和被统治阶级之间的矛盾时必须采取审慎的态度，因为官僚国家利用这一点已经不是一种可能，而是从苏俄建立以来发生了一个世纪的现实，人总不能在同一个地方不停跌倒。

当然读到这些记录的人也不要认为我在这些概念使用上就毫无建树，对于中国以外不了解的事物确实没有办法，但是在有关中国历史的概念上我还是做了很多拨乱反正的工作。例如中国的官方说法把秦朝至清朝叫做我国的封建时期，我显然完全抛弃了这种欺骗百姓的傻瓜理论。在我的叙述中，把秦代两汉一直到西晋称为古典帝国或者古典时期的中国，而我所说的“封建中国”只是指公元三、四、五、六世纪四百年间的中国社会，也即国际汉学界所说的“早期中世纪中国”。从七世纪到清朝结束，我一直采取“复辟官僚国家（社会）”这一称呼，同时指出复辟官僚国家是从宋代开始成熟的。对于中国这样处于官僚制度压迫下的统治阶级和以西欧和日本为代表的封建制度下的统治阶级的称呼也做了区分，在中国我就将他们称为“地主阶级”，除了对南北朝时期封建化比较明显的政权，或者是像大理这样已经封建化的边疆政权才会采取对欧洲和日本统治阶级同样的称呼即“封建领主”。

读者还有一个或许会产生明显疑问的地方在于当我把欧洲和日本对照的时候两边的称呼会产生明显的差异，例如按照日本人自己的划分，当中世结束之后马上就已经是近世了。可是按照中文学界对欧洲的一般划分的翻译，当中世纪在 1453 年结束之后，显然与欧洲人认为的“近代”还存在相当距离，这之间的时间被命名为“早近代”，或者按照当时所发生的重大历史事件命名为“宗教改革和启蒙运动时期”。我的处理办法是，把西方所谓的“early modern”也统一在汉语中使用“近世”或者“近代”表述，一般不再采用“早期近代”的这个说法。对于 1800 年之后的欧洲我会直接用“现代”进行描述，而临近现在的时期则称为“当代”。相关原因在第 12 章第 30 节中进行了说明。

我想说的是，之所以欧洲和日本的时代划分在中文翻译上产生这样的大的差异，是因为欧洲是一个比日本大很多的，有许多不同政权的大陆。事实就是，1453 年作为标定中世纪结束的时间节点，根本原因是在大陆两端发生了百年战争结束和东罗马帝国灭亡这样的标志性历史事件，但是并不意味着社会结构在如此广大的区域内短时间内发生的巨变，这与日本自从织田信长上洛到丰臣秀吉病逝 30 年间疾风骤雨般的变化是完全不同的。而且人们应当习惯两个“典型的”社会阶段之间存在过渡是不可避免的事情，例如当人们提到欧洲的绝对主义国家时，首先，联想到的一定是波旁王朝统治下的法国。但是绝对主义国家真的是到十七、十八世纪才开始出现吗？如果人们观察到马基雅维利写的《君主论》，那么不难发现这部呼吁一个强大君主拯救意大利（当然作者本人还是最终希望共和）的著作出版于 1532 年，这个时候全欧洲还没有哪个国家能够被明确地说是绝对主义国家。但是人的思想却不可能脱离社会现实而存在，马基雅维利能写出《君主论》多少说明他所处的社会中已经产生了很多支持绝对主义国家形成的因素

（例如对公民态度的重视，夺取统治地位方式的多样化和君主的用人之道等），绝对主义国家已在形成当中。这也就是我为什么认为从中世纪这样典型的封建社会借书再到典型绝对主义国家形成之间没必要再单独划出一个阶段，仅仅将其视为过渡时期的“近世社会”的较早部分就足够了，无论是宗教改革运动还是启蒙运动本身都是这种过渡的一种显著外在表现。

至于为什么我将欧洲人所认为的绝对主义国家与日本人所认为的近世国家划等号，原因在于江户幕府的很多特征的确与欧洲绝对主义国家相同。但是我又不得不说，江户幕府的发展程度到底没办法跟西欧的英法等国相提并论，这是因为日本的国家规模，外交规模和地理位置所决定的，同时也是日本封建化开始较晚的结果。就如同人们很容易指出江户幕府与欧洲绝对主义国家最为显见的一点不同，那就是绝对主义国家的军事支出占财政支出比例极高而且极度好战，相反江户时期是日本历史上极为罕见的长期和平的年代，日本的大规模扩张恰恰是幕府结束之后的明治到昭和前期。可话又说回来，就像我在写日本部分就已经提到过的，日本社会比起欧洲来讲起步晚太多，它的每一个“标准的”的历史时期往往得等到最后一段时间才能表现出典型性，比如说所谓的古典日本只有在平安时期的最后 100 年的院政时代才是真正有明显古典国家特征，所谓的中世日本只有在最后 100 年的战国时期才最终实现了和欧洲基本相同的封建社会，所以日本的近世社会也存在这种滞后性再正常不过了。完全没有必要为了一个“尾巴”而放弃全身，就像日本人不会把院政之前的平安时代不叫古典日本一样，也不会把战国之前的镰仓和室町前期不叫中世社会一样。当人们提到安土桃山政权非常重视和依赖都市与流通时，当人们关注到江户町人丰富的物质和精神生活时，这就已经肯定了江户时期的日本具有近世国家的特征，具有绝对主义国家的特征（市民阶级力量壮大）。日本人在说“近世”的时候强调的是时代上的特征，欧洲人在说

“绝对主义”的时候强调的是社会表现上的特征，我就干脆把两点合起来说成“近世绝对主义国家（社会/阶段）”，这应该不会造成阅读上的困难。

我个人在命名方面也存在一些问题，只能请读到的人多担待，例如我在描述民族大迁徙时期蛮族进入中国内地之后没有选择按照一般的社会发展规律封建化，而是与中国的汉族地主进行妥协转而采取官僚化政策的时候称这种妥协为“地主-官僚妥协”，这个命名显然容易造成误解，让人误以为妥协的双方是官僚和地主。而且对于对中国历史较为了解的人更容易将它误认为另一种社会现象，也就是已经复辟的官僚国家通过官位荣禄来“收买”作为大土地主的门阀士族。认为我是在描述类似于有唐一代士族向长安、洛阳两京产生集中化趋势背后的政治行为。这里我承认是我在命名的时候有一些草率，其实我想表达的是地主和官僚之间的那个小横杠应该被看作一个向右的箭头，意思是蛮族“放弃成为地主转而成为官僚”（当然更精确的说法是“放弃成为封建领主转而成为官僚化地主”），不过读的人显然不太可能最初就采取这种理解方式。如果从妥协的双方来进行命名的话，应该是“蛮族-地主妥协”。而且在史料上很遗憾的一点是，因为中国的封建化对我们来说已经是十五六个世纪前十分遥远的事了，在那个缺少印刷术，纸张也刚刚普及的年代史料不可能像后来那样丰富，本来就有限的史料经过这么长的时间散佚现在能读到的就更少了。所以除了像刘渊和刘宣争论匈奴应当采取何种路线那样不甚具体的记录，我们不可能找到像《建炎以来系年要录》那般直白和露骨地记载以研究当时的人是怎么看待这种妥协，这也是没办法的事。

至于那些汉语中很普遍的翻译问题就更多了，例如在中国“皇帝”和“帝制”已经滥用到了一种没办法重新梳理的程度，波斯最高统治者叫皇帝，马里的最高统治者叫皇帝，莫卧儿的最高统治者叫皇帝，罗马的最高统治者叫皇帝，神圣罗马帝国的最高统治者还叫皇帝。虽然哪怕人人都知道这些外国的君主跟中国的皇帝完全不一样，甚至于官僚复辟帝国的中国皇帝跟秦汉古典帝国的皇帝也已经差异极大了，但是这样的称呼还是被保留下来，对于对人类历史有一定了解的人来说这应该不会造成困扰。希望读到的人不要忘记我思考并写下这些文字本身就是在有学业任务，并且在信息接触方面受到种种限制的情况下完成的，存在不足在相当多时候都是无可奈何的事情。最后我必须吐槽的是23年年初的电影《流浪地球2》，虽然这个破电影跟我写的东西没有一点关系，但是我居然买了票去看这种传达反人类价值观的烂片，不吐槽一下简直不是我的风格。中国的自诩的爱国者们总是沉湎于这些近乎是幻想中的宏大叙事，对于自己同胞眼前可见的诸多困难是从来都不多看一眼的，更不能指望这些家伙帮忙说一两句好话了。我居然写了这么多东西之后还因为一个打着爱国旗号的电影被骗了二三十块钱，这真是过去一年里干过的最没脑子的行为。